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Generation Z's screen culture: Understanding younger users' behaviour in the television streaming age – The case of post-crisis Greece

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Abstract

Post-crisis Greece is experiencing dynamic audiovisual market growth, faster than the EU average. As Greek TV responds to the challenges of the streaming era, new paths are forged by young viewers/users. This article, based on a survey of nearly 1,000 students, attempts to characterise the viewing patterns of young audiences, who are early adopters and heavy consumers of streaming television. We argue that whereas young Greek media users favour streaming platforms, they value the social character of

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traditional television, which plays a prominent role in post-crisis Greece. Young media users' screen behaviour can be described as mobility-centred and algorithmically naïve.

Keywords
Generation Z, Greece, television, streaming platforms, recommendation systems

Introduction

In 2010, former Time Warner CEO, Jeff Bewkes, remarked on the expansion of Netflix and other video-on-demand services: 'It's a little bit like, is the Albanian army going to take over the world? I don't think so' (Arango, 2010). Looking back now, this statement could be characterised as the 'tragic irony' in a Greek tragedy. Since then, the TV industry has changed dramatically in ways we could not possibly have imagined.

Based on a generational perspective and audience evolution theories, the present article aims to facilitate a better understanding of the screen culture of young media users, who are early adopters and heavy consumers of audiovisual content in the television streaming age. For Generation Z (Gen Z), streaming is not a new way of watching television, despite its differences to the traditional model, but rather a new generation's concept of what television viewing is (Tremor Video and Hulu, 2017).

A survey of nearly 1,000 people between 18 and 25 years old was conducted to explore the viewing patterns of Gen Z in Greece, regarding traditional, satellite and streaming television platforms (see RQ1 below) and how the suggestions of recommendation systems affect their viewing choices (see RQ2). Since there are no cable TV options in Greece, our research deals with free-to-air traditional TV and also subscription-based TV platforms. As 'traditional TV' we refer to broadcast TV channels, while under the term 'TV platforms' we include both local satellite platforms and streaming television platforms (local internet protocol television providers or IPTVs and global over-the-top television providers or OTTs). Unfortunately, at the time of conducting the research, Greek OTT services had yet to be launched.

Media consumption differs from the consumption of other services because media content can be seen as a symbolic system (Grindstaff, 2015). We draw from the approaches of Jenkins (2006) and Livingstone (2015) to account for the modern diverse and fragmented audience and their media usage. In this study, we employ the term 'media user', an individualistic term, as opposed to the collective term 'audience' (Livingstone, 2015). A media user can be characterised by varying degrees of interpretative, selective and productive engagement with a range of media devices, content and contexts (Picone, 2017).

The article examines the user patterns of Gen Z, particularly in relation to streaming platforms and their algorithmic recommendation systems. In order to contextualise the specific experiences of Greek users, the evolution of television in the streaming age along with the emergence and the significance of the recommendation systems is discussed in the next section followed by the description of Gen Z's screen culture. Prior to the analysis of the original research, the Greek television landscape is presented focusing

on the last decade and the relationship of young Greeks with the medium which can explain some of the specifics of Greek Gen Z's media use which will be analysed in the final section.

Evolution of television in the streaming age

Our contemporary era of digitisation and convergence that followed the broadcast TV and the cable and commercial eras can be theorised as streaming age. What we call in this work the 'streaming age' is marked by trends of changing distribution and advertising models and growing numbers of channels, platforms and audiences, which are increasingly fragmented and autonomous (see Napoli, 2012).

Broadcast television delivered freely over the air (OTA) keeps the sense of 'liveness', with live shows, sports games and news, operating as 'ordinary TV' (Bonner, 2003). This landscape includes satellite and cable viewing options and, more recently, streaming (content delivered over the internet). The convergence of internet and television has given rise to IPTV and OTTs.

Aiming at exploring technology-driven needs and the social outcomes of media use in the streaming age, we focus on how people engage with affordances of convergent media such as activity, personalisation, choice and control (Tefertiller and Sheehan, 2019). Thus, recommendation systems are another important focus of our research.

Recommendation systems are data-mining software tools which recommend suitable items to a user or group of users (Alam et al., 2019). They are based on the principle that users' previous preferences/activities are recorded and updated regularly, revealing the most relevant items from the broad content spectrum of the provider, giving a more personalised experience (Roy et al., 2018).

Television streaming services rely heavily on recommendation systems, allowing the experience they offer to be better customised towards personalised viewing. One of the main factors of Netflix's success is that they continually improve their content value using data generated from tracking consumer preferences and behaviours. In other words, they enhance Netflix's worth as a product: as there are now vast repositories of audiovisual material, it is impossible for users to search entire databases to find content that would please them. Therefore, recommendation systems may bring forward selective material considering previous choices of the user. In this way, the content itself gains value too, since it is not obscured anymore. It is thus little surprising that the company characterises recommendation systems as a key pillar of their product (Gomez-Uribe and Hunt, 2015).

In the streaming age of internet-distributed television (Lotz, 2017), where audiences exert increasing control over the parameters of their viewing, it makes sense that streaming technology, given the capabilities of recommendation systems, should address the concerns of programme selection and attention (Podara et al. 2021; Tefertiller and Sheehan, 2019). Gen Z have a particularly high requirement for filtering relevant content to alleviate information overload (Benselin and Ragsdell, 2016). However, an issue introduced by the employment of these systems is whether a computational procedure, utilising algorithms to sort and classify the habits and preferences of media users, can

make 'optimal' predictions/decisions regarding cultural products (for example, movies), thus creating an 'algorithmic culture' (Hallinan and Striphas, 2016).

The screen culture of Generation Z

Generation Z refers to people who were born after 1995 and cannot remember the intersection between the analogue and digital world. As Tapscott (2008) argues, it is not age per se but one's generation that affects media motivations and use. Gen Z is the first generation to have grown up with on-demand television content availability for most of their lives (Tremor Video and Hulu, 2017). For them, the perception of television viewing is no longer an exclusively domestic experience. They do not return home and turn the TV on; they have easier access to media content; and they are constantly 'on' (Podara et al., 2020). They are also accustomed to being in control of their own media environment and furthermore they use different affordances of each medium according to their needs (Siapera et al., 2019). Unlike previous generations, they do not habitually watch traditional TV in a way that Rubin (1984) would define as ritual viewing and Moseley et al. (2014) as a routine watching. Thus, they readily embraced streaming.

In the era of big data, Gen Z is exposed to a vast amount of streaming content, which may create stress and lessen their enjoyment of media use (Benselin and Ragsdell, 2016). Therefore, they are selective, taking in information instantaneously but losing interest just as fast (Veglis and Maniou, 2018). Additionally, they are 'mobility centrics', prioritising the usage of mobile small screens (that is smartphones, tablets) for television viewing (Ericsson Consumer Lab, 2017; Tremor Video and Hulu, 2017).

The case study of Greece

The evolution of television is as much a global history as it as a local one, reflecting particularities related to the structures of the society within which it operates (Maniou, 2017). Greece was selected as a case study since it is a small European TV market facing several specific challenges in its screen culture. Following a rather turbulent period after the recession of 2008, the country has in recent years experienced a dynamic growth in the audiovisual market – one of the fastest growth rates in Europe (Council of Europe European Audiovisual Observatory, 2019). It is also interesting that Greeks present, by far, the highest number of hours spent consuming television in Europe, dedicating 3.04 hours a day on screen-related activities (watching traditional TV or other media, playing computer games etc.). This is nearly an hour more than the EU average (mean 2.37; Eurostat, 2018).

Greeks have never been cord-cutters since they do not have a cable TV tradition like many other Western countries whereas subscription-based platforms offering streaming and on-demand audiovisual content just recently entered the market as major players in the country's television landscape. As well as free-to-air broadcast TV, there are satellite and IPTV options. The first subscription-based satellite channel appeared in 1994 (NOVA, formerly known as FILMNET), but saw only slow growth. It was only 15 years later, in 2009, that a second satellite channel was launched, owned by the Greek

telecommunication operator COSMOTE. Also, two IPTVs emerged in 2018: Vodafone TV and Wind Vision. In the early 2020s, all four providers launched OTT platforms, aimed at younger audiences. Another protagonist in the Greek TV landscape is Netflix, which entered Greece in 2016, meeting ever-growing acceptance and popularity, while Amazon Prime Video and Apple TV+ platforms are also present. In the recently re-regulated free-to-air broadcast industry in Greece, the pay-television landscape remains unregulated which is not uncommon in small television industries (Wayne, 2018). In 2016, due to the recession, high taxes were imposed on the local subscription-based TV platforms, including a luxury tax on consumers. This has increased the cost of subscriptions, keeping subscriber growth rates almost frozen since then, hovering around one million customers (Mandravelis, 2019). Taxes are not applied to global distribution services, like Netflix and Amazon Prime.

The economic crisis after 2008 brought major shifts in the Greek broadcasting industry, not only due to financial challenges but also to disputes over media credibility (Bantimaroudis and Maniou, 2020; Pleios, 2013) and distrust in journalism (Kalogeropoulos, 2017). Amid accusations of overstuffed bureaucracy and corruption, the public broadcaster ERT was abruptly shut down in 2013, only to reopen in a re-structured form a few months later (Iosifidis and Katsirea, 2014). In the private sector, there were two milestones of the austerity crisis: a) the bankruptcy of two out of eight nation-wide private broadcasters (ALTER in 2012 and MEGA in 2018) and b) the re-regulation of private television broadcasting in 2016, when the Greek government launched an auction of broadcast licenses to replace the seven television stations that had been operating with non-permanent licenses since deregulation (1989). Among the characteristics of recession-period television was the notable reduction of drama content on Greek TV (Nielsen, 2019) and the rise of traditional broadcast viewing, which in 2018, for viewers aged between 18 and 54, increased by 11 minutes a day in comparison to 2002 (Vamvakas, 2018). In the contemporary media environment, the distrust in legacy media remains while there are also low levels of trust in journalism. Greeks prefer to get informed from online platforms, with 32% of Greeks using YouTube for news content (Kalogeropoulos, 2017).

The cohort of Greek Gen Zers has grown up in an era of financial instability and social violence (for example, terrorist attacks), with corruption and media distrust high on the average family's discussion agenda. Therefore, Gen Z's 'fresh contact' (Mannheim, 1928/1952) with traditional television during these recession years can explain their distrust of the medium (Podara et al., 2019b): Mannheim argues that the relationship between generation and media usage is shaped by the generation's original contact. Their relationship with TV was a 'love-hate affair'. Having limited screen options, they have been raised with television as their main entertainment option.

Not surprisingly, in the streaming age of proliferating television content, streaming platforms have taken a prominent role in the daily lives of young audiences. Nielsen indicates in the 2017–2018 TV Yearbook that Gen Z and Millennials in Greece do not give preference to traditional television. Those aged 18 to 34 watch between 1 hour 51 min a day (men) and 2 hours 51 min (women). These are low scores compared to the average Greek viewer that watches, surprisingly, about 4 and a half hours of television

per day. According to Nielsen's data of the same year (2017–2018), viewers of traditional Greek TV are mostly women 55+ (429m/day), women 18+ (405m/d) with low education and men 55+ (359m/day). The traditional TV audience in Greece can therefore be described to be an aging audience.

What does this mean for the industry? Gen Z, who are now entering the workforce, comprise 20% of the total population, which will be a significant portion of the market both in terms of consumer purchasing power and as workers in the years to come. As the audiovisual industry tries to find new ways to respond to the challenges of an evolving media landscape, it is timely to address questions about *what* and *for whom* we should broadcast digitally.

Methodology

This study aims to assess viewing preferences, contributing to an ongoing academic discussion on the determinant factors and characteristic features of generational media habits. We explore the viewing habits of Gen Z, identifying trends in their media usage regarding streaming television and how recommendation systems are perceived and operated. The research seeks to answer the following research questions:

- RQ1: What are the viewing patterns of Generation Z in Greece, regarding traditional, satellite and streaming television platforms?
- RQ2: How do recommendation systems affect their viewing patterns?

The study does not consider the use of user-generated content (that is IGTV), focusing on curated audiovisual content delivered in Greece freely and under subscription and the RQ2 refers to global OTT platforms available in Greece at the time of the research (Netflix & Amazon Prime).

The research was conducted among 18–25-year-old students at Aristotle University of Thessaloniki in May 2019. An online questionnaire was delivered via email through the official mailing lists of the University to all enrolled students regardless of their demographics, having received the ethical clearance of the institution. Prior to the main research, a pilot survey among 25 students at the Laboratory of Media Informatics in the School of Journalism and Media was administered to ascertain the effectiveness of the questionnaire.

The web platform of the survey was open to replies for 10 days, and in that period, it was completed by 944 students, 67.7% women, 32.3% men. However, media consumption in relation to gender was not analysed, as preliminary data from the authors' qualitative studies indicate that there is no significant gender difference in the use of OTT among this generation. Subsequently, the completeness, consistency and plausibility of the responses were checked, resulting in the final number of 934 usable answers which were then coded and transferred to a specially formulated sociological matrix of SPSS (version 25.0).

Table 1. Statistical distribution of the demographic variables.

Factors	Answers	Frequency	Percentage
Academic discipline (Faculties)	Agriculture, Forestry and Natural Environment	68	7.3%
	Health Sciences	73	7.8%
	Sciences	199	21.3%
	Fine Arts	61	6.5%
	Law and Economic and Political Sciences	140	15.0%
	Education, Theology and Physical Education and Sport Sciences	93	10.0%
	Engineering	162	17.3%
	Philosophy	138	14.8%
Residence	Parent's home	367	39.3%
	Student's own apartment	351	37.6%
	Shared apartment	178	19.1%
	Halls of residence	33	3.5%
	Guest in someone else's apartment	5	0.5%
Population of place of origins	Up to 10,000 inhabitants	148	15.8%
	10,000–50,000	153	16.4%
	50,000–100,000	134	14.3%
	100,000–1,000,000	185	19.8%
	More than 1,000,000	314	33.6%

Research sample

The sample represents $\sim 2\%$ of the total number of enrolled students in Greece and consists of a near-proportionate group of students from all academic disciplines. Such a wide range avoids potential biases resulting from an over-representation of any particular field of study. Furthermore, the students' places of origin also broadly represent the country's wider population, since, in terms of student enrolment, Aristotle University is the largest institution of higher education in Greece (Table 1). Participants originate from a wide range of places, from small villages to large cities, resulting in a geographically varied sample of Gen Z in Greek higher education. In Greece, the majority of youth graduating high school choses to continue their studies in universities or colleges. According to Greek official statistics (Hellenic Statistical Authority, 2018) almost 80%, out of the approximately 100,000 high school graduates per year, are enrolled on university programmes. Of course, there is a drop out percentage after the first year of studies, which results in more than half of the youth in the age group of 18–23 to be considered part of the student population. Besides that, significantly different results are not expected in the case of inclusion of non-students in the research since Gen Z, in general, are acquainted with technology use and are also heavily consuming media. Previous qualitative research of the authors has indicated that no significant difference could be expected in the media use of non-students, relevant to their educational level (Podara and Kalliris, 2021).

Initially, to test the reliability and the internal consistency of the research on a multi-item scale, Cronbach's alpha was carried out on the overall total and groups of questions, resulting in a = 0.688 (overall) to 0.733 (recommendations' group) and 0.777 (statements' group).

Regarding the main part of the research, the variables involved frequency of use of the platforms in general and then of specific content categories (for example, films, sports, series, etc.). The survey also asked about devices used (for example, TV sets with decoders, tablets, smartphones, etc.), personal navigation (for example, username and password use) and features of the platforms that are suitable to the viewing habits of Gen Z, such as viewing content unconstrained by time contexts or programme scheduling, lack of time and device constraints and commenting and sharing. Finally, the influence of system recommendations on participants' choices was examined.

Findings

The initial aim was to map Gen Z's daily media usage routine to help in later identification of patterns of behaviour. The findings were organised in terms of the questions concerning *what* and *when* they are watching, on *which* screen, *why they watch TV platforms* and *how* they choose the content.

RQ1: What are the viewing patterns of Generation Z in Greece, regarding traditional, satellite and streaming television platforms?

The data reveals that a significant number of Gen Zers *never* watch traditional broadcast TV (28.3%). However, they have not totally moved away from it, with a respectable 16% stating that they watch broadcast TV *every day*. As expected, watching YouTube is a daily habit for 69.6% of them (Figure 1).

44.3% never use web TV platforms of traditional broadcast channels to consume traditional TV channel's content on demand. Despite the opportunity for video-on-demand (VOD) viewing, our participants seem less interested in traditional TV's content, regardless of the viewing experience.

Satellite and streaming television preferences

Subscription-based TV platforms are used by 52.6% (N = 491) of the participants (usage time in Figure 2). This penetration rate in Gen Zers is higher than the rate of the general population, which is estimated at 44% as of the summer of 2019 (Focus Bari, 2020). As observed, although Netflix is the most popular platform, only 22.8% use the platform daily while the other platforms are infrequently used (Figure 2).

A 5-point Likert scale (totally disagree to totally agree) on fixed statements was used to find out the reasons that would lead a young person to choose a TV platform. The respondents were asked to state their degree of agreement or disagreement regarding a variety of characteristics of Gen Z's audiovisual consumption on subscription-based TV platforms. The selected factors resulted from a literature review and the authors'

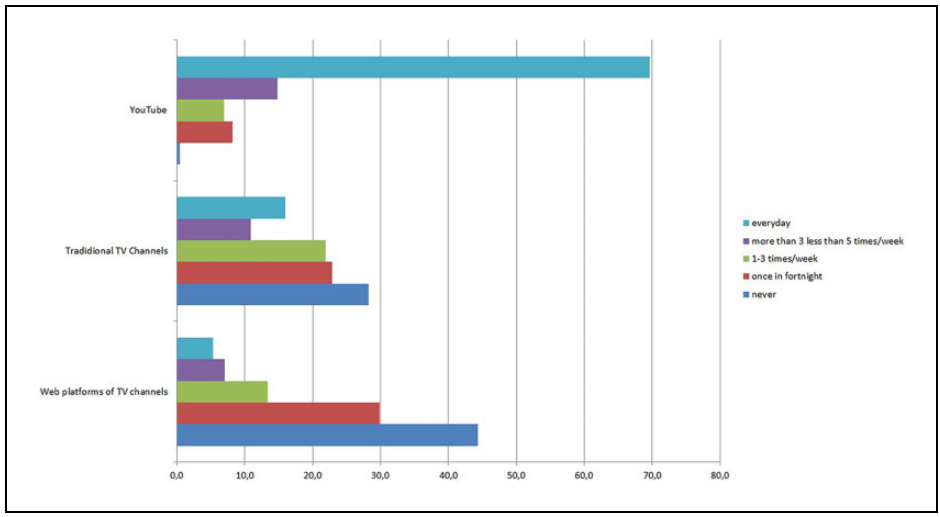


Figure 1. Frequency use of preferred choices for watching video.

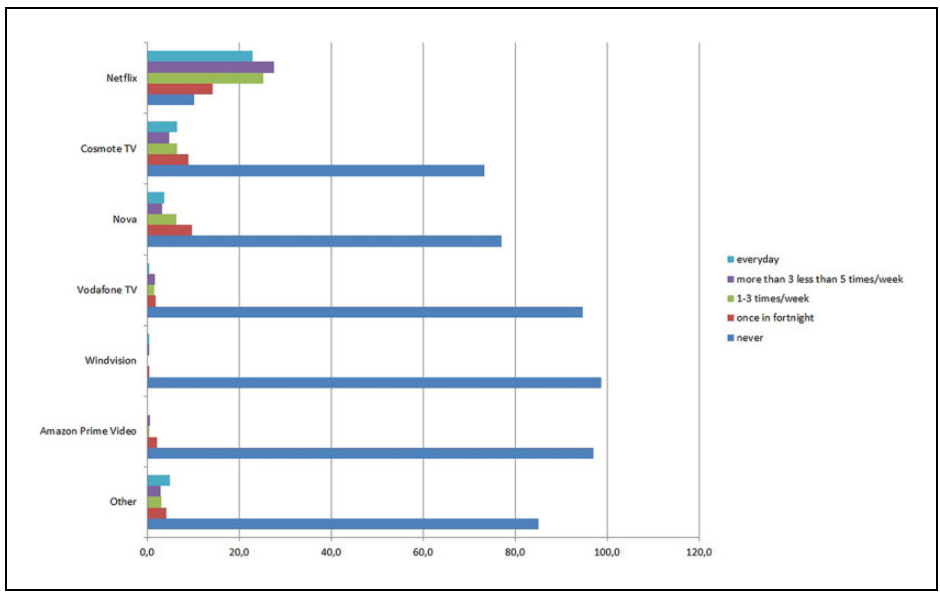


Figure 2. Frequency use of subscription-based TV platforms.

previous qualitative studies (Podara et al., 2019b). The data received is analysed in terms of mean and standard deviation (StD) values.

The television platforms are mainly favoured for the flexibility they allow in viewing content unconstrained by time contexts or programme scheduling, such as being able to

Table 2. Devices used to access content on a subscription-based TV platform.

	Mean	StD
TV set with decoder	2.49	1.515
TV set with game console	1.51	1.009
PC	2.06	1.419
Smart TV	2.40	1.545
Laptop	3.80	1.384
Tablet	1.65	1.152
Smartphone	3.99	1.418
Other	1.21	1.21

continue watching from the point I stopped (mean = 4.51 StD = 0.773) and *I can watch as many episodes as I want* (mean = 4.17 StD = 0.952), shifting the users away from 'appointment viewing'. Also, the viewers highly value the lack of time and device constraints: *I can watch anything I want at the time that I want* (mean = 4.33 StD = 0.982) and *I can watch the content of a subscription-based TV platform on many different devices* (mean = 4.14 StD = 0.897) with *ad breaks* (mean = 4.16 StD = 1.104). On the contrary, they are not really interested in the process of *commenting and sharing* (mean = 2.91 StD = 0.991) and *having access to other viewers' comments* (mean = 2.77 StD = 1.079), which corroborates findings in the international literature (Gomez-Uribe and Hunt, 2015).

Screens used for watching TV platforms

Regarding the devices used to access content on a subscription-based TV platform, the findings reveal a mobile-centric approach, a typical characteristic of Gen Z viewers (Ericsson Consumer Lab, 2017; Nielsen, 2019; Podara et al., 2019a). The question employed a 5-point Likert scale (*never* to *every day*). As presented in Table 2, a TV set with decoder or a smart TV is used 1–3 times per week. The most frequently used screen is a smartphone with a laptop a close second.

Content consumed via satellite and streaming television

Additionally, participants were asked about their viewing preferences on TV platforms. As Figure 3 depicts, a significant percentage (34.8%) watch series daily and movies 1–3 times per week (38.9%), whereas the least watched categories are sports and news.

As a second level of investigation, Gen Z's viewing patterns were extracted through statistical analysis to identify particular characteristics of their preferences. The Spearman correlation analysis was performed, seeking relationships among users' viewing patterns. The modes of media usage related to streaming television that we anticipated are as follows.

Netflix viewers have a different viewing profile to viewers of TV platforms. The majority of heavy Netflix users, for whom the platform is a substitute for traditional TV,

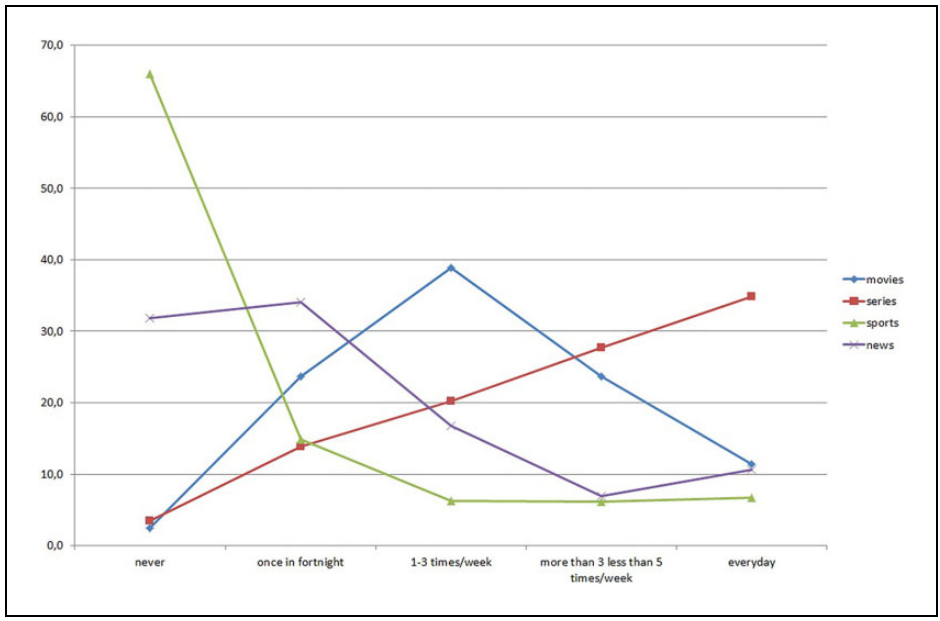


Figure 3. Viewing preferences on satellite and streaming TV platforms.

following the functional displacement model (Twenge et al., 2019), never watch traditional TV (cor.coe -179). On the other hand, the other platform users are heavy users of traditional TV (cor.coe 259 for COSMOTE TV users and cor.coe 234 for NOVA), who consider pay TV a supplement to traditional TV, reflecting the complementary model (Twenge et al., 2019) with 59.4% and 61.1% of COSMOTE TV and NOVA users respectively watching broadcast TV daily.

The above results can be attributed to the different profiles of local and global distribution TV platforms. Netflix identifies itself as 'the new internet television' (Tefertiller and Sheehan, 2019), promoting an experience comparable to traditional TV (with a recent change to a horizontal cinema template and a dark interface) while also investing in unique content. On the other hand, local subscription-based TV platforms can be better described as portals (Lotz, 2017). They combine on-demand content with sports broadcasting, providing many paid and free channels divided into categories, such as live national and local sports, films, kids' programmes, etc. Even other OTTs are offered through these portals (that is, Wind Vision offers Netflix). Apart from COSMOTE TV, which has recently started to invest in original programming, the others continue to invest in live sports broadcasting to gain subscribers.

To participants, Netflix is the preferred option for watching movies (cor.coe 327) and series (cor.coe 589), while other television platforms are used for watching sports (COSMOTE TV cor.coe 381 and NOVA cor.coe 232). This pattern can be explained by the media usage behaviour mentioned earlier: a) Young people prefer to consume

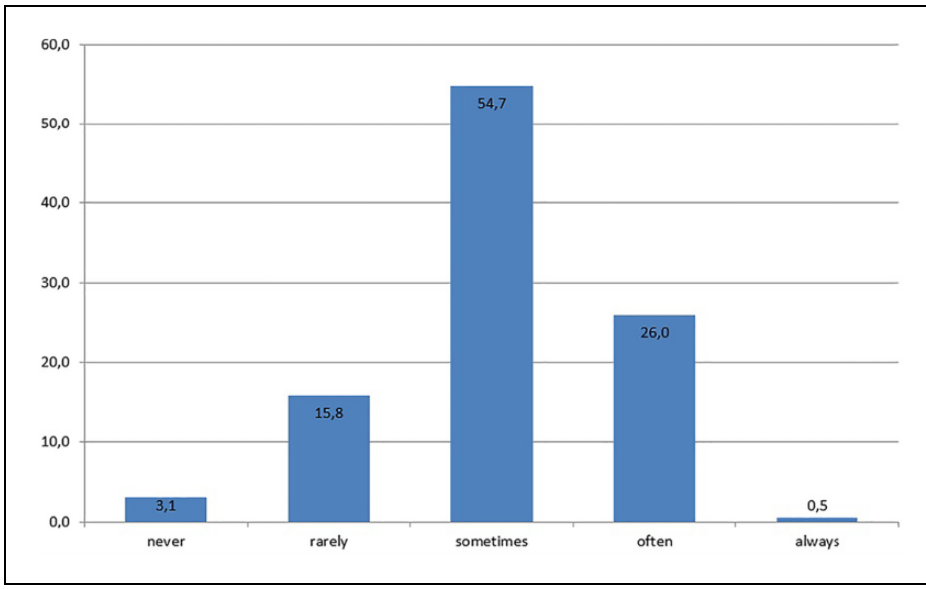


Figure 4. Perceived helpfulness of TV platform proposals.

entertainment content on the platforms and b) Netflix is by far their top choice. This can be explained by the difference in the subscription cost. In addition, only 21.5% of TV platform viewers surveyed pay the expenses of the platform themselves, while in 51.5% of the cases, the subscription is a family member's expense. After all, 39.3% of the total number of students who took part in the research reside in their parents' home. In other cases, the cost is shared among other family members (for example brothers and sisters) as well as with friends.

RQ2: How do recommendation systems affect Gen Z's viewing patterns?

Besides screen and platform usage, it is necessary to understand how the emerging cohort of Gen Zers is making choices in the proliferating television environment. A recommendation system works as a kind of information filtering system that provides personalised approaches to users facing a huge amount of available choices. In our research, more than half of the participants who used global streaming platforms were not aware of what a recommendation system is (51.7% gave a negative reply), although they do take into consideration the platforms' proposals and think that *sometimes* (54.7%) and *often* (26%) these proposals are helpful (Figure 4). Furthermore, they mentioned that their choices are affected *sometimes* (54.5%) or *often* (16.3%) by the suggestions when connected to a global streaming platform.

As data on a five-point scale question (never to always) reveals, respondents are not very interested in rating content they have watched (mean 2.17 and StD = 1.194). Only

22.2% of those who rate content notice differences in the subsequent platform recommendations. This is not surprising since in many content recommendation tasks, users rarely provide explicit ratings (in a sense of grading a production with a number of stars) or direct feedback (as in commenting of adding 'likes') when consuming frequently updated online content (Yi et al., 2014).

The recommendation systems do take into account the user's content consumption behaviour; however, it is important that users understand why a video was recommended to them. They have to be aware that the choices they made were saved, processed and, in that way, individually recommended material was delivered back to them. The competence to understand, integrate and evaluate this process is related to information management and, consequently, digital literacy skills. It is significant for users to understand the usefulness of the recommendation systems, which function in their favour, since the vast databases of video content would be useless without the search and retrieval mechanisms. However, it seems that Gen Z tend towards passive behaviour as far as their streaming television viewing decisions are concerned. They rely on the algorithmic culture to make decisions for them and decide what appears on their screens (Lotz, 2014) without having second thoughts about content that may have been obscured. This new screen culture characteristic (Beer, 2013; Van Dijck, 2013), which has emerged out of the streaming age, is taken for granted by young audiences, who are used to having their online experience customised and curated (Seemiller and Grace, 2018)

The data also indicates that Gen Zers trust web platforms, in contrast with the distrust that they traditionally show legacy media (Podara et al., 2018, 2019b). The participants were asked whether they use a username and password when connected to subscription-based TV platforms or other streaming platforms (like YouTube, Twitch, Vimeo) or are having second thoughts on revealing to the platform their content consumption behaviour through implicit feedback. Nearly half of them (52.1%) prefer this procedure (Figure 5) while 19.6% do not consider providing personal data to be an issue.

Conclusions and discussion

To better conceptualise the media habits of this new generation, the research asked, what are the viewing patterns of Generation Z in Greece, regarding traditional, satellite and streaming television (RQ1)? The responses indicate that young media users in Greece mostly turn their back on traditional television, as almost one third of them mentioned they never watch broadcast TV. However, a noteworthy 16% watch traditional TV daily, even though it is not their top preference. One of the main reasons for this is their proximity to parents, who usually belong to Generation X (called the 'TV Generation' or 'couch potatoes'), for whom television is a daily routine (Strauss and Howe, 1991). This family viewing activity can also be attributed to the fact that many of them live with their parents for financial reasons or 'crowded-nest syndrome' (Caputo, 2019).

Most young media users are not intrigued by any kind of content of traditional TV, even when it is offered on demand (for example, web TV platforms). This is probably related to Gen Z's preference for entertainment content, such as series and movies, especially since, as stated, these are their favoured content on subscription-based TV

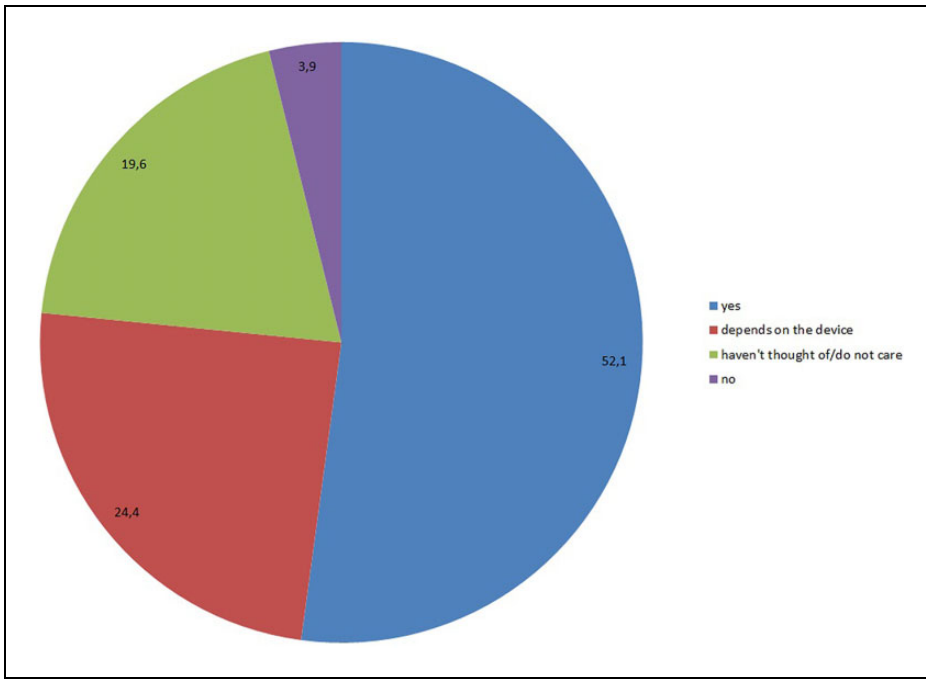


Figure 5. Username & password use.

platforms. Traditional Greek television, coming out of a crisis period, has focused on news content and minimised the production of Greek fiction. Meanwhile, the local broadcast industry has employed no strategies for content youthification, focusing instead on older, financially strong consumers. Growing up in a digital environment, young people are used to turning to web platforms in order to consume audiovisual content that interests them.

The penetration rate of OTT platforms in Gen Zers is higher than the rate in the general population of Greece, but still their consumption is not a daily habit. Netflix is by far their top choice among subscription-based TV platforms. Their favoured screens for viewing streaming platforms are smartphones and laptops, confirming mobility-centric viewing and the preference for smaller screens that has also been noticed by international peers.

A Spearman's correlation analysis revealed that Netflix, which is preferred for movies/series viewing, can be considered as a substitute for traditional TV; most of its heavy users never watch traditional TV. In contrast, local TV platforms, selected mostly for sports, are a supplement to traditional TV viewing, meaning their users are also heavy users of traditional TV.

Another difference that was identified was that Netflix is preferred for movies/series viewing while COSMOTE and NOVA are used mostly for sports. This can be attributed

to the different profiles of local and global distribution OTTs. Given the localised nature of the Greek television industry, OTT platforms should be considered more as a supplement than as a substitute/competitor to traditional broadcasters. Since Gen Zers use different media to fulfil different needs, the pluralised and personalised content of television platforms can complement the social character and the liveness of traditional broadcasting. In this way, they can co-exist under the same roof (or platform). Moreover, Gen Z's preference for Netflix can be more related to the higher subscription cost of local TV platforms than to the content. Given the fact that they are both here to stay, more regulatory decisions are necessary in order to deal with emerging streaming television.

As we move further into the streaming age, with young audiences being exposed to more and more TV content, it is important to understand how their choice is arrived at (RQ2: How do recommendation systems affect GenZ's viewing patterns?). The findings indicate that only half of the Gen Zers who use global streaming platforms are aware of what recommendation systems actually are, although the majority use them: 68.8% take into consideration the platform recommendations and 81.7% of this percentage consider recommendations helpful. Gen Zers take for granted the algorithmic decisions structuring their television viewing and value personalised content. They trust streaming television, without having second thoughts about its use, which contrasts with the distrust that they traditionally show broadcast TV. Although they do not typically provide direct or explicit feedback (like ratings), they consent to supplying personal data, revealing to the platform their content consumption behaviour through implicit feedback. It is typical that the more familiar users get with a technology, the more invisible it becomes to them (Livingstone, 2002). The recommendation systems are taken for granted, invisibly supporting viewing practices of young media users. It would be fair to say that 'algorithmically naïve' users consent to the mining of their data by algorithms. This is indicative of their surface level usage of digital media (Henderson et al., 2017), since having been born in a digital world does not mean they possess 'media literacy' by default (Matsiola et al., 2019).

As the post-crisis television industry of Greece progresses further into the streaming era, the new paths posed by the young generation of viewers/users need to be taken into consideration. While the streaming era is not 'killing TV', it brings many new challenges for the television industry and also issues around citizenship and the role of the state in media literacy education. As technological structures continue to evolve for every provider involved in the process, it is the authors' belief that, at the end of the day, the content will be the variable that wins over consumers.

Looking ahead

This study identifies certain limitations that could be investigated by future research. The Covid-19 pandemic of 2020 seems to have affected the television industry and needs further investigation. For example, in Greece two new TV platforms were created (CINOBO/private and ERTFLIX/public) with high expectations regarding future audience penetration. Another limitation that every generational analysis faces is that of generalities. Apart from the existence of intra-generational differences, there are also

variations of factors such as media literacy and the digital divide. With internet access being a prerequisite for television viewing in the streaming era, a new kind of digital chasm may be created. Thus, future research could explore how streaming television fits into the lives of young people who may belong to this generation, however, due to the digital divide, may not present the same socio-economic affordances.

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